

1. **Kadaknath chicken (in Khasi sesame curry)**
2. **Tree tomato (Oberoi calls it naga-guac. With the special fruit found in the northeastern belt)**
3. **Dhindo (Nepali thick gruel-style porridge)**
4. **Tingmo (Tibetan steamed bun)**
5. **Aithang aka chameleon root (dressed in wild coriander)**
6. **Bamboo and dale chilli pickle**
7. **Steamed fish (in kon jolokia oil)**

the focus of industrial-scale cropping during the Green Revolution and, later, as western products like cakes, cookies, pastas, breads gained popularity. Now, they are emerging as an alternative to wheat, and can be used not only for rotis, khichdis and other grain-based dishes, but also in western items like pizzas, pastas, cakes and cookies. "Millets have a variety of micronutrients that wheat does not," says Bhushan, "be it iron, zinc, magnesium, folic acid or calcium."

This does not mean you eliminate wheat rotis or pasta from your diet. Experts warn against self-diagnosing oneself with coeliac disease, a trend that has seen India become the place where gluten-free diets are most popular compared to other countries, according to Nielsen's global ingredient trend report in 2016. "There is no need to be extreme," says Rajeshwari V. Shetty, head of dietetics at the S.L. Raheja Hospital in Mahim, Mumbai. "If you feel discomfort eating gluten, go ahead and cut it out; millets have a lot of benefits. But don't torture yourself to cut out a food group if you have no symptoms and just because others are."

The interest in millets means restaurants are designing their menus accordingly. At the Sheraton Grand Bangalore Hotel in Bengaluru, Executive Sous Chef Gaurav Bansal features millets as the centrepiece of the menu and has introduced items like millet-based pancakes and French toast for breakfast. "Millets are not only nutritious but also highly versatile, aligning perfectly with the increasing interest in healthier and sustainable dining options," he says. Health, though, isn't the only reason for their use in menus, they genuinely taste good too, says Suvir Saran, the culinary director at Bastian, Bizza and Binge in Mumbai and Bengaluru. At the first-of-its-kind sensory experience hosted by Blue Label at The Oberoi in Gurugram, he served shrimp with an Alleppey curry and a chivda made with millets. "I haven't stopped hearing about the genius of that flip for better health and greater taste and textural contrast," says Saran. "At ITC," says Manisha Bhasin, corporate executive chef, "we have been championing sustainable food for decades now and regularly create menu items based on fresh, hyperlocal and sustainable ingredients. These are very well received, particularly dishes created with forgotten grains like millets."

But even this miracle grain has its limitations. Some millets contain phytic acid, which can reduce absorption of nutrients from a diet. "It is usually recommended that whole millets are soaked in water for a couple of hours," says